state minister Bharat Singh Kushwaha, considered close to assembly Speaker Narendra Singh Tomar. Scindia explains why the perception about his contesting from Gwalior may have arisen. "As a Rajya Sabha member, I secured approvals for Kendriya Vidyalayas in Chanderi and Ashoknagar, major roads in the region, seven train connections for Guna. As Guna MP, I got work done in Gwalior and, as Gwalior MP, my father got work done in Guna," he tells INDIA TODAY. "This impression perhaps stems from the high visibility of the airport built in Gwalior in record time, spanning 250,000 sq. ft, larger than those in Bhopal and Indore. However, I've also got approvals for airports in Guna and Shivpuri."

Ask him how the NDA plans to fulfil its ambition of *char sau paar*, and Scindia says, "Our seat counts will increase through our allies and the expansion of the BJP in the eastern and southern parts of the country. We will certainly do better in Maharashtra." And he asserts that it is not merely a slogan. Scindia also dismisses concerns about potential changes to the Constitution if the BJP wins a 400-plus majority. "A party that has been built on the edifice that the Constitution is the sole repository of the Indian soul will never do this.... Not even an iota of a possibility exists of doing anything other than empowering people, such as through an amendment granting 33 per cent representation to women in Parliament," he says.

So, will Guna return a Scindia again after the lapse in the last election? With a lotus in hand, that may just come to pass on May 7. ■

"HAD I NOT PULLED DOWN THE CONGRESS GOVT IN 2020, THE FUNDS ALLOCATED FOR PROGRAMMES LIKE KISAN SAMMAN NIDHI AND LADLI BEHNA WOULD HAVE BEEN POCKETED BY CONGRESS LEADERS"

Jyotiraditya Scindia
Union Minister of Civil Aviation

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Digvijaya's Last Stand

Digvijaya Singh makes a comeback to the Rajgarh Lok Sabha constituency after 33 years as the Congress candidate, employing a grassroots-style campaign. The contest is expected to be fierce

By Rahul Noronha *in Rajgarh*

It's a cruel 40 degrees in Rajgarh, the north-central Madhya Pradesh district that shares its border with Rajasthan. But the group of men assembled under a neem tree in Sonkatch village within the Narsinghgarh sub-division do not seem to be noticing it. Dressed in colourful headgear, they are engrossed instead in an animated conversation as they wait for the arrival of Digvijaya Singh. The former chief minister has been nominated by the Congress to contest in the Rajgarh Lok Sabha constituency after 33 years. Just as their conversation peaks, Singh makes an entrance at the village *chaupal* and proceeds straight to the temple to seek the blessings of the local deity before commencing his address to the gathered crowd.

Singh first entered the Rajgarh electoral scene in 1984, securing success only to face defeat the following election in 1989. He regained the seat in 1991 in a close battle against BJP ideologue Pyarelal Khandelwal. Elevated to chief ministership two years later, Singh maintained an interest in both the affairs of the district as well as the dynamics in the LS seat. A lot has changed in the constituency in 33 years, with sharper caste distinctions and heightened demands for employment.

Challenging Singh is two-term BJP MP Rodmal Nagar, who won with a margin of 431,000 votes the last time. Recognising the scale of the challenge, Singh approaches what he deems his final election with a fresh strategy—a grassroots-focused campaign mirroring panchayat-style engagements to counter the influence of the Modi phenomenon.

"We have a parliamentary style of democracy in the country, in which you elect the person who represents you in Parliament in Delhi. I present my services to you as a lawyer who would represent your case in Delhi. If you think the present MP did a good job, elect him again. However, if you believe I can serve you better, sign the *vakalatnama* by voting for me on May 7," he tells the electorate at Sonkatch. "The BJP is urging you not to focus on the local candidate, but to vote for the party and Modi. If that's the case, Modi should have contested from Rajgarh. Who would you turn to tomorrow if you have any issues?" he asks. He also brings up price rise, writeoff of corporate loans and the need for the continuation of farm loans in MP, which are an instant hit among farm-based voters. By turning the contest into Singh versus Nagar one instead of Singh versus Modi, the Congress knows it could be in the fight, failing which Rajgarh will become a hat trick for the BJP.

The Congress has its strengths of course. Following Singh's appointment as CM and subsequent resignation from the Rajgarh Lok Sabha seat, his brother Laxman Singh had won it for the Congress in 1994. Lax-